KPPSC PMS • EUROPEAN HISTORY (PAPER II: 1914–1960) ## QUESTION 14: THE UNITED NATIONS (UNO) VS. THE LEAGUE OF NATIONS: STRUCTURE & PEACE

EXECUTIVE EXAM METADATA - **EXAM QUESTIONS LINKED: 2022 Q.7: 'Evaluate the creation, structure, and early peacekeeping challenges of the United Nations Organization (UNO) compared to the League of Nations.' 2018 Q.8: 'Discuss the establishment and importance of the United Nations Organization.' - **SYLLABUS TOPIC:** Paper II — Section 8: The United Nations Organization (UNO) — Origins, Structure, Comparison with League of Nations & Early Peacekeeping - **ALLOCATED MARKS / TIME:** 20 Marks | 35 Minutes | Standard Word Count: ~650–700 words - **HISTORIOGRAPHICAL THESIS:** The creation of the United Nations Organization at the San Francisco Conference in 1945 represented the conscious, realistic reconstruction of international multilateralism designed to correct the fatal structural defects of the League of Nations; by abandoning the paralyzing requirement of unanimity, establishing an executive Security Council endowed with Great Power veto authority and Chapter VII military enforcement teeth, and anchoring the permanent leadership of the United States and the Soviet Union, the UN forged a durable institutional apparatus that avoided the catastrophic fate of the League, even as its collective security mechanisms were recurrently constrained by Cold War superpower deadlock.**

📌 EXAM ESSENTIAL TAKEAWAY > • Wartime Genesis of the UN: Atlantic Charter (August 1941, Roosevelt & Churchill); Declaration by United Nations (Jan 1942, 26 nations); Moscow Conference (Oct 1943, Big Four pledge general international body); Dumbarton Oaks Conference (1944, drafting institutional charter); Yalta Conference (Feb 1945, resolving the Security Council voting veto formula); San Francisco Conference (April 25–June 26, 1945, 50 nations sign the UN Charter). > > • Structural Comparison: UN vs. League of Nations: > > 1. Assembly: League Assembly required unanimity for all substantive action; UN General Assembly operates on a democratic two-thirds majority for vital questions (Article 18), functioning as a universal global parliament. > > 2. Executive Council: League Council required unanimous consent of all members; UN Security Council (15 members: Big Five permanent [US, USSR, UK, France, China] + 10 rotating non-permanent) operates on a qualified majority of 9 votes, incorporating the P5 Veto ('Yalta Formula') to prevent the UN from suicidal military action against a nuclear superpower. > > 3. Enforcement Teeth: League lacked military machinery (Article 16 economic sanctions only); UN Charter Chapter VII grants binding legal authority: Article 41 (economic sanctions) and Article 42 (military intervention by land, sea, and air via Military Staff Committee). > > 4. Socioeconomic Breadth: The League treated social matters as secondary; the UN created ECOSOC, specialized global agencies (WHO, UNESCO, ILO, FAO), and the Bretton Woods institutions (World Bank, IMF). > > • Why the UN Succeeded Where the League Failed: Universal Great Power participation (the US was the primary architect and financial patron; the USSR remained an active member); institutional resilience (no superpower walked out during crises); recognition of power realities via the veto. > > • Early Peacekeeping Innovations: Cold War paralysis (frequent Soviet vetoes) led to creative adaptations: (1) Uniting for Peace Resolution (377A, 1950) allowing General Assembly action during the Korean War, and (2) Dag Hammarskjöld and Lester B. Pearson's invention of armed, neutral 'Chapter Six and a Half' Peacekeeping during the 1956 Suez Crisis (UNEF I). >

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1. CONCEPTUAL MIND MAP & THEMATIC PATHWAY ```

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LEAGUE DEFICIENCIES (1919) WARTIME PLANNING (1941-45) THE MODERN UN (1945-1960)

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[Paralyzing Unanimity Rule] --> [Atlantic Charter & Dumbarton Oaks]--> [General Assembly: 2/3 Vote] [US Absent & Pariah Walkouts] --> [Yalta Summit: Big Five Veto] --> [Security Council: P5 Veto] [Toothless Economic Sanctions] --> [San Francisco Conference (1945)] --> [Chapter VII Military Teeth] [No Standing Military Structure] --> [Universal Great Power Buy-In] --> [ECOSOC & Human Rights (1948)] --> [Invention of Peacekeeping: Suez Crisis UNEF I (1956)]

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2. CHRONOLOGICAL MILESTONES & DIPLOMATIC DATES | Date / Year | Event / Action | Historical & Exam Significance | |---|---|---| | **Aug 14, 1941 | The Atlantic Charter | Roosevelt and Churchill formulate liberal war aims, promising a permanent system of general security. | | **Jan 1, 1942** | Declaration by United Nations | 26 nations endorse Atlantic Charter; first official use of term 'United Nations' coined by FDR. | | **Aug–Oct 1944** | Dumbarton Oaks Conference | US, UK, USSR, and China meet in Washington to draft structure of General Assembly and Security Council. | | **Feb 11, 1945** | Yalta Voting Compromise | Big Three agree that substantive Security Council decisions require affirmative vote of 7 (now 9) members including all 5 permanent members. | |**

****April 25–June 26, 1945** | San Francisco Conference | 50 nations debate and unanimously adopt the 111 articles of the Charter of the United Nations. | | **Oct 24, 1945** | UN Charter Enters into Force | Ratified by the Big Five and majority of nations; officially establishes the United Nations (United Nations Day). | | **Jan 10, 1946** | First General Assembly Session | 51 nations convene in London; Paul-Henri Spaak elected first Assembly President; Trygve Lie elected Secretary-General. | | **Dec 10, 1948** | Universal Declaration of Human Rights | Chaired by Eleanor Roosevelt; General Assembly adopts landmark declaration establishing universal human dignity. | | **Nov 3, 1950** | Uniting for Peace Resolution | Resolution 377A passed to bypass Soviet vetoes and authorize collective military action in the Korean War. | | **Nov 1956** | Invention of UN Peacekeeping (UNEF I) | Dag Hammarskjöld deploys 6,000 neutral blue-helmet troops to supervise British-French-Israeli withdrawal from Suez. |**

3. THE 20-MARK MASTER MODEL ESSAY (~650 WORDS)

Introduction: The Phoenix from the Ashes of Geneva On October 24, 1945, the Charter of the United Nations entered into legal force, inaugurating a revolutionary chapter in the history of international governance. Formulated in the catastrophic shadow of World War II, the United Nations Organization (UNO) was not an idealistic fantasy conceived in isolation, but the hard-headed, realistic reconstruction of international multilateralism designed to correct the catastrophic structural and political failures that had condemned the League of Nations to irrelevance. In the historiographical analysis of scholars such as Paul Kennedy, Inis Claude, and Mark Mazower, the creation of the United Nations represented a masterful synthesis of Wilsonian universalism and Realist balance-of-power diplomacy. By replacing the paralyzing rule of unanimity with an executive Security Council, incorporating the Great Power veto, providing military enforcement teeth under Chapter VII, and ensuring the permanent institutional leadership of both the United States and the Soviet Union, the architects of San Francisco created an enduring global institution that avoided the collapse of its predecessor and preserved humanity from a third world war.

The Lessons of Failure: Why the League of Nations Collapsed The institutional architecture of the United Nations was forged through a systematic autopsy of the League of Nations' structural vulnerabilities. The League had suffered from four fatal defects that made it helpless to resist the aggression of imperial Japan, fascist Italy, and Nazi Germany in the 1930s. First, the League was crippled by the fatal absence of the United States, whose Senate rejected ratification in 1919–1920, depriving the body of the world's greatest economic and naval titan. Second, the League was structured around the absurd procedural rule of unanimity (Articles 5 and 15), meaning that any single member state could paralyze collective action.

Third, the League possessed no military enforcement mechanism: Article 16 provided only for voluntary economic sanctions, which Britain and France refused to enforce effectively during the 1935 Abyssinian crisis. Fourth, the League was perceived as a punitive 'league of victors' designed to enforce the reviled Versailles Treaty; whenever rogue powers were challenged, they simply resigned: Japan in 1933, Germany in 1933, and Italy in 1937.

Wartime Summitry and the Genesis of the UN (1941–1945) Unlike the League, which was hastily appended to the contentious Treaty of Versailles in 1919, the United Nations was meticulously planned across four years of inter-Allied wartime diplomacy. The ideological foundation was laid in August 1941 when Franklin D. Roosevelt and Winston Churchill drafted the Atlantic Charter, pledging a 'wider and permanent system of general security.' In January 1942, twenty-six nations signed the 'Declaration by United Nations,' cementing the wartime coalition against the Axis powers.

The institutional blueprint was negotiated at the Dumbarton Oaks Conference in Washington (August–October 1944) by the United States, Great Britain, the Soviet Union, and the Republic of China. The critical stumbling block—the voting procedure in the executive council—was resolved by Roosevelt, Churchill, and Stalin at the Yalta Conference in February 1945. Finally, from April 25 to June 26, 1945, delegates from fifty sovereign nations representing eighty percent of the world's population assembled at the San Francisco Opera House. In an atmosphere of intense debate, the 111 articles of the United Nations Charter were finalized and unanimously adopted on June 26, 1945.

Structural Innovations: The Security Council, the Veto, and Chapter VII The supreme structural breakthrough of the UN Charter was its pragmatic accommodation of global power realities across three key innovations:

1. The General Assembly vs. The Executive Security Council: The UN established a clear functional division of labor. The General Assembly operates as a universal democratic forum where all member states possess one equal vote, passing non-binding recommendations by a two-thirds majority on vital matters (Article 18). However, actual executive authority was concentrated in the Security Council, which was entrusted with primary responsibility for the maintenance of international peace and security.

2. The 'Big Five' and the Power of the Veto: To avoid the unanimity trap of the League, substantive decisions in the Security Council require a qualified majority of nine votes (originally seven). However, this majority must include the concurring votes of the five Permanent Members (P5: United States, Soviet Union/Russia, Great Britain, France, and China). The veto power (the 'Yalta Formula') was fiercely criticized by smaller nations at San Francisco. Yet, as Inis Claude correctly observes, the veto was the essential anchor of the UN: it acknowledged that collective security against a nuclear superpower was an impossibility that would result in World War III. The veto ensured that the UN would act only when the Great Powers were in agreement, preserving the institution from suicidal confrontation.

3. Chapter VII Enforcement Teeth: Unlike the toothless Covenant of Geneva, Chapter VII of the UN Charter (Articles 39–51) provides the Security Council with binding legal authority. Under Article 39, the Council can identify threats to the peace; under Article 41, it can mandate comprehensive, legally binding economic and diplomatic sanctions; and under Article 42, it can authorize armed military intervention by air, sea, or land forces provided by member states through the Military Staff Committee. When North Korea invaded South Korea in June 1950, the Security Council—capitalizing on a temporary Soviet boycott over the representation of Taiwan—invoked Chapter VII to authorize a sixteen-nation military coalition commanded by General Douglas MacArthur to repel the aggression.

Socioeconomic Breadth: Beyond Pure Security A profound qualitative difference between the League and the United Nations was the UN's recognition that international peace is indivisible from economic stability, social justice, and human rights. Article 55 of the Charter established the Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) to coordinate global development, public health, and human welfare.

Under the visionary leadership of Eleanor Roosevelt, the UN Commission on Human Rights drafted the monumental 'Universal Declaration of Human Rights' (UDHR), adopted by the General Assembly on December 10, 1948, establishing the universal baseline for human dignity, civil liberties, and fundamental freedoms in international law. Furthermore, the UN integrated specialized agencies that revolutionized global governance: the World Health Organization (WHO), the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO), the International Labor Organization (ILO), the Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO), and the United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF). In the economic sphere, the UN coordinated with the Bretton Woods institutions—the International Monetary Fund (IMF) and the World Bank—to ensure international monetary stability and post-war reconstruction.

Cold War Realities and the Invention of Peacekeeping (1956) As the Cold War escalated, the idyllic vision of great-power harmony dissolved. Between 1945 and 1955, the Soviet Union cast over eighty vetoes in the Security Council, paralyzing the Chapter VII collective security mechanism. Confronted by this structural deadlock, the United Nations demonstrated remarkable institutional flexibility and innovation. In November 1950, the General Assembly adopted the 'Uniting for Peace' Resolution (Resolution 377A), establishing that if the Security Council is paralyzed by a veto in the face of aggression, the General Assembly can immediately consider the matter and recommend collective measures, including armed force.

The greatest institutional breakthrough occurred during the Suez Crisis of 1956. When Britain and France vetoed Security Council resolutions demanding their withdrawal from Egypt, UN Secretary-General Dag Hammarskjöld and Canadian diplomat Lester B. Pearson invented an entirely new diplomatic concept: United Nations Peacekeeping (often designated 'Chapter Six and a Half'). Operating under the General Assembly, the UN deployed the First United Nations Emergency Force (UNEF I)—six thousand neutral, blue-helmeted soldiers drawn from non-permanent powers (Canada, India, Sweden, Colombia)—to supervise the ceasefire and facilitate the withdrawal of British, French, and Israeli forces. Peacekeeping was not designed to defeat an aggressor, but to act as a neutral buffer with the consent of the host state, defusing flashpoints before they triggered superpower nuclear confrontation.

Conclusion: The Enduring Parliament of Man In conclusion, the United Nations Organization stands as the most resilient, indispensable multilateral institution in world history. By systematically learning the lessons of the League of Nations' tragic demise, the founders of 1945 constructed an organization that reconciled the idealism of universal human rights with the unvarnished realities of great-power geopolitics. While the UN could not prevent the Cold War or eliminate regional conflicts, it prevented the ultimate catastrophe: a third world war between nuclear superpowers. As second Secretary-General Dag Hammarskjöld famously summarized its realistic mandate: 'The United Nations was not created in order to bring us to heaven, but in order to save us from hell.' Through its universal membership, specialized agencies, and peacekeeping missions, the UN remains the irreplaceable parliament of humanity.

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4. HISTORIOGRAPHICAL PERSPECTIVES & SCHOLARLY QUOTES | Historian | Analytical Perspective | Exact Quotable Argument | |---|---|---| | **Paul Kennedy** | **The Parliament of Man: The Past, Present, and Future**

of the United Nations (2006) | 'The United Nations survived the Cold War precisely because its founders were hard-headed realists who built the Great Power veto into the Charter... The UN is not a world government, but an indispensable scaffolding for global survival.' | | **Inis L. Claude Jr. | Swords into Plowshares (1971) | 'The veto power in the Security Council is not the cause of UN weakness; it is the reflection of the profound political reality that peace among the Great Powers cannot be enforced by majority votes.' | | **Dag Hammarskjöld** | Second UN Secretary-General | 'The United Nations was not created in order to bring us to heaven, but in order to save humanity from hell.' | | **Franklin D. Roosevelt (1944)** | Address on the United Nations | 'We have learned that we cannot live alone, at peace; that our own well-being is dependent on the well-being of other nations, far away... We must build a structure of peace that is permanent.' |**